



MICROAGGRESSION AWARENESS WORKBOOK

A Practical Guide to Recognition, Response, and Resolution



Based on the LLI Framework: Listen, Learn, Implement

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- Personal stories, experiences, and reflections shared during exercises
- Case studies and examples discussed in group settings
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INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the LLI Consulting Group Microaggression Awareness Workbook. This resource is designed to help individuals and teams develop deeper understanding of microaggressions—those brief, everyday exchanges that send denigrating messages to certain individuals because of their group membership.

The LLI Framework: Listen, Learn, Implement

This workbook follows our proven three-phase approach to organizational change and individual growth.

SECTION 1: UNDERSTANDING MICROAGGRESSIONS

Watch the Introduction Video



Scan QR code to watch: What Are Microaggressions? (5 minutes)

1.1 Definition and Impact

Microaggressions are brief and commonplace daily verbal, behavioral, or environmental indignities that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative slights and insults toward members of marginalized groups. While often unintentional, their cumulative effect can significantly impact workplace culture, psychological safety, and organizational performance.

Three Types of Microaggressions:

- **Microassaults:** Explicit derogatory attacks meant to hurt the intended victim
- **Microinsults:** Subtle communications that convey rudeness and insensitivity
- **Microinvalidations:** Communications that exclude, negate, or nullify thoughts and feelings

1.2 Common Examples in Professional Settings

- Assuming someone is in a support role based on their identity
- Asking "Where are you really from?"
- Complimenting someone for being "articulate" with surprise
- Touching someone's hair without permission
- Mistaking a professional for support staff
- Making assumptions about technical ability based on age or gender
- Excluding team members from informal networking opportunities



SECTION 2: LISTEN - RECOGNIZING MICROAGGRESSIONS

Watch: Recognition Strategies



Scan QR code to watch: How to Recognize Microaggressions (7 minutes)

2.1 Self-Awareness Assessment

Recognizing microaggressions begins with honest self-reflection. Consider your own experiences and behaviors.

Reflection Exercise 1: Personal Experience Inventory

Take 10 minutes to reflect on these questions. Write your responses in the space below or in a separate journal:

1. Describe a time when you witnessed or experienced a microaggression:

2. How did it make you (or the target) feel?

3. Have you ever unintentionally committed a microaggression? What did you learn?

2.2 Environmental Scan

Microaggressions don't only occur in interpersonal interactions. They can be embedded in organizational policies, physical spaces, and systemic practices.

Workplace Environment Checklist:

■ Do our meeting spaces accommodate different accessibility needs?

- Are diverse voices regularly invited to contribute in meetings?
- Does our imagery and decor reflect the diversity of our community?
- Are professional development opportunities equitably distributed?
- Do our policies account for different cultural practices and religious observances?

SECTION 3: LEARN - UNDERSTANDING IMPACT

3.1 The Intent vs. Impact Gap

One of the most challenging aspects of addressing microaggressions is the gap between intent and impact. Good intentions do not negate harmful impact.

Key Principle: *When someone tells you that you've hurt them, you don't get to decide that you didn't.*

3.2 Cumulative Effect

While a single microaggression might seem minor, the cumulative effect of repeated incidents can lead to:

- Decreased psychological safety and wellbeing
- Reduced engagement and productivity
- Increased stress and health challenges
- Higher turnover rates
- Damage to organizational culture and reputation

Research Insight: Studies show that microaggressions can have similar psychological effects as overt discrimination, particularly when experienced regularly over time.

Reflection Exercise 2: Impact Assessment

Think about a time when your actions or words had an unintended negative impact. How did you respond when you became aware of the impact?

SECTION 4: IMPLEMENT - RESPONSE STRATEGIES

Watch: Effective Response Techniques



Scan QR code to watch: How to Respond (8 minutes)

4.1 If You Experience a Microaggression

You have options for how to respond. There is no single "correct" response—choose what feels safe and appropriate for your situation.

Response Options:

- **Immediate Address:** "That comment made me uncomfortable. Here's why..."
- **Seek Clarification:** "What did you mean by that?"
- **Name the Pattern:** "I notice this assumption keeps coming up..."
- **Take Time:** "I need to think about what just happened. Can we talk later?"
- **Seek Support:** Talk to a trusted colleague, manager, or HR representative

4.2 If You Witness a Microaggression

Allies play a crucial role in creating inclusive environments. When you witness a microaggression:

Interrupt with Curiosity:

- "Can you help me understand what you meant by that?"
- "I'm concerned about how that might have landed. Can we revisit it?"

Redirect the Conversation:

- "Let's refocus on [person's] actual contribution to this project."
- "I think we're making an assumption here. Let's check that."

Follow Up Privately:

- Check in with the person who experienced the microaggression
- Have a learning conversation with the person who committed it

SECTION 5: IMPLEMENT - MAKING AMENDS

5.1 If You Commit a Microaggression

Everyone makes mistakes. What matters most is how you respond when made aware of harm.

The 4-Step Accountability Process:

Step 1: Listen Without Defense

- Resist the urge to explain your intent
- Focus on understanding the impact
- Avoid centering your feelings of guilt or shame

Step 2: Acknowledge the Impact

- "Thank you for telling me. I understand that my comment/action caused harm."
- "I appreciate you taking the time to help me understand the impact."

Step 3: Apologize Sincerely

- "I apologize for [specific action/statement]."
- "I take responsibility for the impact of my words/actions."
- Avoid qualifiers like "if" or "but"

Step 4: Commit to Change

- "I'm committed to doing better. Here's how I plan to..."
- Actually follow through with changed behavior
- Do your own learning rather than asking the harmed person to educate you

What NOT to Say:

- "I didn't mean it that way."
- "You're being too sensitive."
- "I have [marginalized identity] friends."
- "That's just how I was raised."
- "Can you help me understand how I offended you?"

Practice Exercise: Crafting Your Apology

Imagine you made an assumption about a colleague's technical skills based on their age. They addressed it with you privately. Write your response using the 4-step process:

SECTION 6: ORGANIZATIONAL IMPLEMENTATION

Watch: Creating Systemic Change



Scan QR code to watch: Building Inclusive Organizations (10 minutes)

6.1 Moving Beyond Individual Awareness

While individual awareness is important, lasting change requires organizational commitment and systemic approaches.

Organizational Strategies for Prevention:

1. Policy and Procedure:

- Establish clear reporting mechanisms
- Create accountability systems for leadership
- Include microaggression awareness in harassment policies
- Implement restorative justice approaches when appropriate

2. Training and Development:

- Regular training for all staff (not just one-time sessions)
- Leadership accountability training
- Practice-based scenarios and role-playing
- Ongoing learning communities and discussion groups

3. Hiring and Advancement:

- Review hiring practices for implicit bias
- Examine promotion pathways for equity
- Ensure diverse representation in leadership
- Create mentorship and sponsorship programs

4. Culture and Environment:

- Foster psychological safety in team meetings
- Regularly audit physical and digital spaces
- Celebrate diverse cultural practices and holidays
- Create employee resource groups with real support

Your Organization's Action Plan

Based on what you've learned, identify three concrete actions your organization could take to address microaggressions:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

SECTION 7: YOUR COMMITMENT TO ACTION

7.1 Personal Commitment Statement

Awareness without action is insufficient. Use this space to articulate your personal commitment to creating more inclusive spaces.

My Commitment:

One behavior I will start doing:

One behavior I will stop doing:

One conversation I will initiate:

How I will hold myself accountable:

7.2 Additional Resources

Recommended Reading:

- "Microaggressions in Everyday Life" by Derald Wing Sue
- "So You Want to Talk About Race" by Ijeoma Oluo
- "How to Be an Antiracist" by Ibram X. Kendi
- "White Fragility" by Robin DiAngelo

LLI Consulting Group Services:

- Customized microaggression awareness training
- Organizational culture assessments
- Leadership coaching and development
- Implementation support and accountability systems

Contact Us:

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Closing Reflection:

Creating inclusive environments is ongoing work. This workbook is a starting point, not a destination. Continue to listen, continue to learn, and most importantly—continue to implement what you've learned into daily practice.



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